

The quiet, fraught bid to deport 1 million

Limits of personnel, cash and the law test Trump officials’ first-year goal

BY MARIA SACCHETTI AND JACOB BOGAGE

As the Trump administration aggressively pushes to deport more immigrants during the president’s first year back in office, one aspirational number keeps coming up in private conversations, according to four current and former federal officials with direct knowledge of the plans: 1 million. Deporting 1 million immigrants in one year would ostensibly surpass previous statistics, as the highest number thus far was more than 400,000 a year when Barack Obama was president. But officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the internal goal, aren’t revealing how they are counting the numbers, and analysts say the available statistics make that target appear unrealistic, if not impossible, given funding, staffing levels and the fact that most immigrants have the right to a court hearing before being removed from the country.

White House adviser Stephen Miller has been strategizing with officials from the Department of Homeland Security and other federal agencies on an almost daily basis to meet that goal, two of the current and former officials said. One strategy to quickly increase numbers, officials have said, is to find ways to deport some of the 1.4 million immigrants who have final deportation orders but cannot be deported because their home countries won’t take them back.

The administration is negotiating with as many as 30 countries to take deportees who are not their citizens, two officials said. In a recent court filing, the administration said it hopes to send “thousands” of immigrants to these destinations, known as third countries.

Though administrations have tried to deport people to third countries for years, this would be

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From stop to stop in New York, she searches for those at risk of harming themselves or others



THE NURSE IN THE SUBWAY

STORY BY RUBY CRAMER WITH PHOTOGRAPHY BY VICTOR J. BLUE IN NEW YORK

The first thing Lisa Singh saw that worried her was the way the woman on the subway platform waved her off. The dismissiveness. Sometimes that was a sign of something. Lisa, a 53-year-old psychiatric nurse, took a step closer and scanned the woman’s face, searching for answers about what kind of care she might need.

The woman was slumped over on a bench at the 34th Street-Herald Square station, one subway stop in a city where the mayor, the governor and now the president were all demanding a more forceful approach to the type of person Lisa was beginning to assess. She and the rest of her team, five police officers and two homeless-outreach workers, huddled around the bench. Lisa saw swelling near the woman’s left eye and a bump on her head. She took out her phone and began taking notes: soiled clothing, malodorous, several large tote bags, a container of raw rice that had spilled onto the platform.

“Hi, I’m Lisa. I’m a nurse,” was how she usually began her clinical assessments, but the woman on the bench wasn’t speaking English. “I will just wait a little, and I will go,” she said in Cantonese, as the team’s NYPD supervisor, Capt. Hanjie Lu, began to translate.

The woman went on to say that it was morning, sometime around 8, that stores would be open soon and that she was waiting here because she had hurt her leg. Or maybe it was her foot. Lu said she wasn’t being clear.

“She believes right now it’s 8 in the morning?” Lisa said, and asked the captain to try reorienting her to the fact that it was nearly 10 p.m.

Lisa had spent the past six months working overnight on the subway platforms of New York, where homelessness, mental illness, drug addiction and crime had been unfolding as overlapping crises. The estimated number of people living outside and underground has grown to its highest

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Lisa Singh, a psychiatric nurse who has spent the past six months working overnights with the NYPD on the city’s subway platforms, speaks with a man at the 34th Street-Herald Square station in New York.

U.S. and China dig in, risk a calamity

SPECTER OF MASS ECONOMIC FALLOUT

Few tools to alter course in tit-for-tat trade war

BY CATE CADELL, LILY KUO AND KATRINA NORTHPROP

The world’s two largest powers are closer to a full economic break than ever, as President Donald Trump and Chinese leader Xi Jinping refuse to back down in a trade war that has become a high-stakes game of chicken — raising the specter of mass economic fallout and heightened risk of conflict between Washington and Beijing.

A week after Trump’s “Liberation Day” tariffs roiled global markets, his administration has put China in its crosshairs, shifting his global trade war from a crusade against what he called foreign freeloaders to a winner-takes-all confrontation with Beijing.

China on Friday countered Washington’s levies by raising tariffs on all U.S. goods to 125 percent, while it dismissed U.S. measures as “economically meaningless” and Xi urged European nations to join Beijing in resisting Trump’s “unilateral bullying.” A day earlier, Trump confirmed he had hiked tariffs on Chinese imports to 145 percent — the fourth such escalation since taking office two months ago. The Trump administration said late Friday that it would exempt many consumer electronics, like the popular iPhone, from tariffs even as it didn’t back down from the broad levies.

But analysts and people close to officials in China’s leadership circles say beneath the growing market panic over the tariffs lies a deeper concern: Trump’s erratic early moves — and the absence of any meaningful back-channel between Washington and Beijing since January — mean there are few tools available to steer the

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New exemptions: Phones, other electronics get tariff carve-out. A16

Syria targets conduit Iran, allies used to prop up Assad

Government forces seek to wipe away ‘land bridge’ with Lebanon that ferried arms, cash

BY LOVEDAY MORRIS AND SOUAD MEKHENNET IN HAWSH AL-SAYYID ALI, SYRIA

From the front seat of a black GMC truck, Maher Ziwani, the Syrian army commander overseeing this stretch of the border with Lebanon, radioed ahead to check the safety of the dirt track stretching to the frontier. But before he got a response, Syrian fighters on a motorbike sped past his window, shouting a warning.

“Hezbollah, Hezbollah!” one yelled. “Hezbollah shot one of our guys!”

A car followed, its interior smeared with blood. A patrol had come under fire, soldiers said.

In recent weeks, Syrian government forces have been trying to choke off smuggling routes that cross the rugged 233-mile border with Lebanon. These routes are the last vestiges of the “land bridge” — a network traversing

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SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Syrian army personnel on March 19, the first day of a ceasefire with Hezbollah in Hawsh al-Sayyid Ali, Syria, a once-vital node in a smuggling network that Syrian forces are trying to eradicate.

White House defied warnings in labeling migrants as dead

Social Security executive is expelled after objecting to unprecedented move

BY HANNAH NATANSON, LISA REIN AND MERYL KORNFIELD

Two days after the Social Security Administration purposely and falsely labeled 6,100 living immigrants as dead, security guards arrived at the office of a well-regarded senior executive in the agency’s Woodlawn, Maryland, headquarters.

Greg Pearre, who oversaw a staff of hundreds of technology experts, had pushed back on the Trump administration’s plan to move the migrants’ names into a Social Security death database, eliminating their ability to legally earn wages and, officials hoped, spurring them to leave the country. In particular, Pearre had clashed with Scott Coulter, the new chief information officer in-

stalled by Elon Musk. Pearre told Coulter that the plan was illegal, cruel and risked declaring the wrong people dead, according to three people familiar with the events.

But his objections did not go over well with Trump political appointees. And so on Thursday, the security guards in Pearre’s office told him it was time to leave.

They walked Pearre out of the building, capping a momentous internal battle over the novel strategy — pushed by Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service and the Department of Homeland Security — to add thousands of immigrants ranging in age from teenagers to octogenarians to the agency’s Death Master File. The dataset is used by government agencies, employers, banks and landlords to check the status of employees, residents, clients and others.

The episode also followed earlier warnings from senior Social Security officials that the database was insecure and could be easily edited without proof of

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